

English

Year 4

Cambridge Early Years

Student Manual



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British English edition.

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INTRODUCTION

How this book works

This is a book about the craft of storytelling. In this first unit you will look inside a story to see how it is built, learn the difference between narrative and dialogue, and write the opening of a story of your own.

How to help

- **Work together.** Read the page aloud, then let your child lead.
- **Talk lots.** The questions start conversations, they do not test.
- **Keep it fun.** Short, happy sessions beat long, tired ones.

A note for grown-ups

This book follows the spirit of an international primary programme, interpreted afresh for Prime School. Every unit grows new skills out of a topic children already care about, and finishes with something to make, draw or write.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Reading the page

Each section follows the same rhythm, so you always know where you are.

PANEL	WHAT IT DOES
In this unit, you will	The goals for the unit.
Let us start	A quick warm-up to wake up what you know.
Listening and speaking	Talk and listen about the topic.
Vocabulary	Learn new words, with pictures.
Remember!	A reminder of something you already learned.
Word book	Write down new words to keep.
Thinking time	A question to think and talk about.
I can	Statements to check your progress.

How to work

Take your time and look at the pictures: they are there to help you. When you see a new word, say it out loud. In Talking time there are no wrong answers, only good ideas.

GETTING READY

Before Unit 1

You do not need much: a pencil, some crayons, a notebook, and someone to work with.

Your toolkit

- Your eyes, for looking carefully at the pictures.
- Your voice, for reading out loud and sharing ideas.

- Your notebook, for writing and drawing what you find.

A little warm-up

- 1 What do you already know about this topic?
- 2 What would you most like to find out?
- 3 Who could you ask if you got stuck?

These are exactly the things Unit 1 will help you with. When you can answer them, you are ready to begin.

1

Stories and storytellers

How stories are built, and how to build your own

© IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- ✓ Talk about stories you know and why they work.
- ✓ Spot narrative and dialogue in a story.
- ✓ Use verb tenses to show when things happen.
- ✓ Plan and write the opening of your own story.

◆ LET US START

Think of a story you love. Tell a partner:

- who the main character is, and what they want
- where and when the story happens
- the moment when something goes wrong

UNIT 1 • PART 1

Talking about stories

• SPEAKING AND LISTENING

In a group, take turns to summarise a story you know in three sentences only: the beginning, the problem, the ending. Listen carefully to the others. Whose summary made you most want to read the story?

UNIT 1 • PART 2

Narrative and dialogue

A story is built from two kinds of writing. **Narrative** is the storyteller's voice, telling you what happens. **Dialogue** is the characters' own words, inside speech marks.

“ EXTRACT • 'THE LIGHTHOUSE KEEPER'S CAT' ”

The storm had been rolling in all afternoon. Duarte climbed the ninety-seven steps of the lighthouse two at a time, with the cat bounding ahead of him.

"The lamp, Grandpa!" he shouted. "It has gone out!"

His grandfather did not look up from the workbench. "Then we shall light it again," he said calmly, "and quickly. There is a fishing boat out there tonight."

Duarte's hands shook as he struck the match. Below them, the sea threw itself against the rocks and roared.

- 1 Find one sentence of narrative and one line of dialogue in the extract.
- 2 What is the problem in this story? Write it in one sentence.
- 3 How does the writer show that Duarte is worried? Find two clues.
- 4 Why do you think the grandfather stays calm? What does that tell you about him?

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Most stories are told in the **past tense**: *climbed, shouted, shook*. Notice how "had been rolling" tells you something started even earlier.

- 1 Write these sentences in the past tense:
 - a. Duarte runs up the steps.
 - b. The cat waits at the top.
 - c. The sea roars against the rocks.

READING TIP

When you meet a new word, read the whole sentence again. The words around it usually give you a clue about what it means.

UNIT 1 • PART 3

Words that describe

■ KEY WORDS

- **narrative**: the storyteller's voice, telling what happens.
- **dialogue**: the words characters say, written inside speech marks.
- **setting**: where and when a story takes place.
- **character**: a person or animal in a story.

- 1 Write three words to describe the setting of the extract.
- 2 Find one word in the extract that shows the sea is powerful.

UNIT 1 • PART 4

Your turn to write

- 1 Plan the opening of a story of your own. Answer these four questions in your notebook:
 - Who is your main character, and what do they want?
 - Where and when does it happen?
 - What goes wrong in the first few lines?
 - What will you keep secret from the reader for now?
- 2 Write your opening. It should be six to ten sentences, and must include at least one line of dialogue.
- 3 Read your opening aloud to a partner. Ask them: what do you want to know next?

⇌ PEER ASSESSMENT

Swap openings with a partner. Tell them: one thing that made you want to read on, and one thing that would make it even stronger.

◆ THINKING TIME

Which is harder to write well: narrative or dialogue? Why do you think that is?

☒ SUMMARY CHECKLIST

- ✓ I can talk about how a story is built.
- ✓ I can tell narrative from dialogue.
- ✓ I can use the past tense to tell a story.
- ✓ I can plan and write a story opening with dialogue.

UNIT 1 • FINAL PROJECT

The class anthology

★ FINAL PROJECT

The class anthology

The class will publish an anthology of story openings, and yours will be in it. Polish the opening you wrote until it is between 150 and 250 words, ready to be read by someone who has never met you.

What to hand in

- Your polished opening, with a title.
- At least one line of dialogue, correctly punctuated.
- A one-sentence note explaining one technique you used.

How it will be judged

Criterion Weight	--- ---	Interest for the reader 35%	Correct use of dialogue 25%	
Description and word choice 25%	Quality of editing 15%			

UNIT 1 • CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

- 1 What is narrative?
- 2 What is dialogue, and how do you punctuate it?
- 3 Name two things that make up the setting of a story.
- 4 Write this in the past tense: 'The cat waits at the top.'
- 5 Write one sentence of dialogue for a character who is frightened.
- 6 What is the difference between a character and a setting?

UNIT 1 • EVALUATION

Be honest. Colour the circle that matches how you feel about each outcome: green means confident, amber means nearly there, red means needs more work.

I CAN ...	GREEN	AMBER	RED
talk about how a story is built	☐	☐	☐
tell narrative from dialogue	☐	☐	☐
use the past tense to tell a story	☐	☐	☐
plan and write a story opening	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 1 • WHAT CAN YOU DO?

✓ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Talk about how a story is built. | ☐ Use the past tense to tell a story. |
| ☐ Tell narrative from dialogue. | ☐ Plan and write a story opening with dialogue. |

GLOSSARY

Unit 1

narrative: the storyteller's voice, telling what happens.

dialogue: the words characters say, inside speech marks.

setting: where and when a story takes place.

character: a person or animal in a story.

past tense: the verb form used for events that already happened.

SOURCES & REFERENCES

Where everything came from

All text and diagrams are original to this edition. The factual claims can be checked here. Links were live as of July 2026.

- 1 'The Lighthouse Keeper's Cat'. An original story written for this book. © Prime School 2026.

Read like a writer. Write like a reader.

This Year 4 Student Book takes stories apart to show how they work, then helps you build your own. You will study an original extract, learn about narrative and dialogue, and write an opening with real dialogue in it.

Written for Prime School pupils, in clear British English, with original stories written for this book.

STORIES

DIALOGUE

DESCRIPTION

WRITING

READING